

PICTOR

THE PAINTER'S EASEL

CONTAINING ONLY FAINT STARS, PICTOR WAS INTRODUCED IN THE 1750S. IT IS FOUND BETWEEN THE STAR CANOPUS IN CARINA AND THE LARGE MAGELLANIC CLOUD IN DORADO.

Pictor is said to represent an artist's easel although its star pattern bears little resemblance to one. It is one of 14 constellations introduced by French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille after observing the southern stars in the 1750s. A generally unremarkable constellation, it nevertheless has some interesting stars. Close-up views of Beta Pictoris reveal it is surrounded by a disk of planet-making material that extends more than 1,000 times the distance from the Earth to the Sun. A planet, named Beta Pictoris b, has already been identified in the inner disk. It has the mass of about nine Jupiters and is almost as close to its parent star as Saturn is to the Sun. The red dwarf Kapteyn's Star is the second-fastest moving star in the sky (after Barnard's Star in Ophiuchus).

KEY DATA

Size ranking 59

Brightest stars Alpha (α) 3.3, Beta (β) 3.9

Genitive Pictoris

Abbreviation Pic

Highest in sky at 10pm
December–February

Fully visible 23°N–90°S



CHART 2

MAIN STARS

Alpha Alpha (α) Pictoris
White main-sequence star

☼ 3.3 ↔ 97 light-years

Beta Beta (β) Pictoris
White main-sequence star

☼ 3.9 ↔ 63 light-years

Gamma (γ) Pictoris
Orange giant

☼ 4.5 ↔ 177 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

NGC 1705
Dwarf irregular galaxy; also a starburst galaxy

Pictor A
Radio galaxy; also a Seyfert galaxy

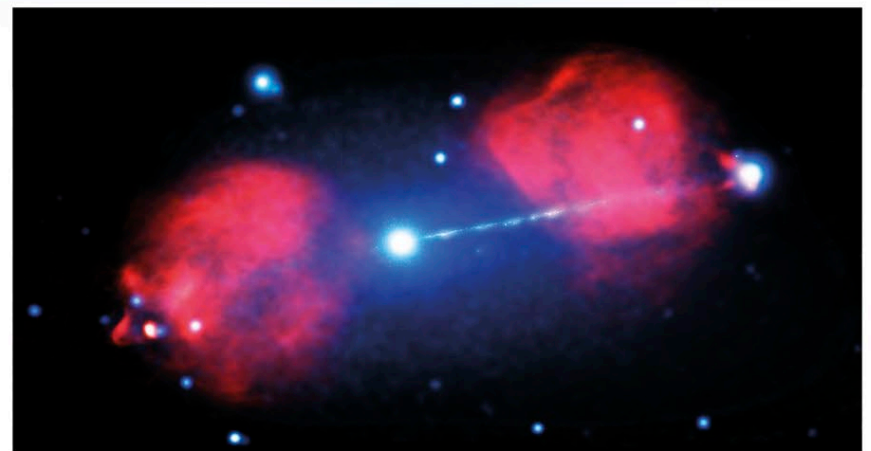
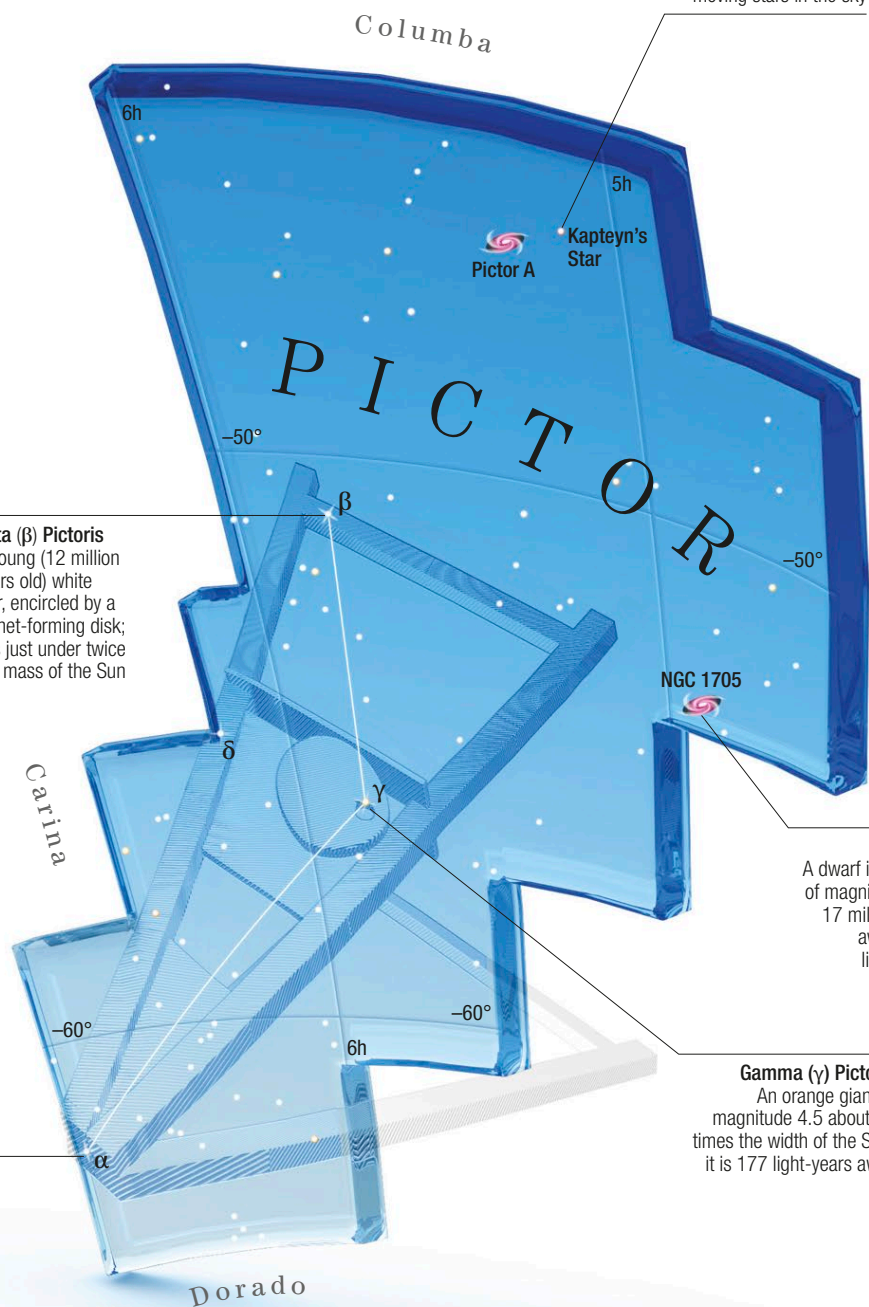
Beta (β) Pictoris
A young (12 million years old) white star, encircled by a planet-forming disk; It is just under twice the mass of the Sun

Alpha (α) Pictoris
Pictor's brightest star. About twice the Sun's mass, it is evolving from a main-sequence star into a subgiant

Kapteyn's Star
A red dwarf of magnitude 8.9, 13 light-years away and one of the fastest-moving stars in the sky

NGC 1705
A dwarf irregular galaxy of magnitude 12.4, it is 17 million light-years away and 2,000 light-years wide

Gamma (γ) Pictoris
An orange giant of magnitude 4.5 about 14 times the width of the Sun; it is 177 light-years away



▷ **Pictor A**
The bright center of this double-lobed radio galaxy is host to a supermassive black hole. As material swirls around the black hole, energy is released as an enormous beam of particles 300,000 light-years in length.